replacing the batteries and trying to turn on the TV with the remote again. You do this, and the TV turns on. Does that mean you were right? No. It's entirely possible that the batteries in the remote weren't dead at all. Maybe the remote has a short and will only work intermittently, no matter what batteries you use. Or maybe the old batteries were in backward, and you didn't notice; you just popped them out and put in new ones pointing the right way. Or maybe something more exotic is going on: maybe the remote always worked, but when you tried it before, the TV mysteriously shifted its picture to the infrared and its sound to the ultrasonic, so you couldn't see or hear it; the TV happened to go back to normal after you changed the batteries, but not *because* you changed them. This last idea is clearly preposterous—how could that happen?—but the point remains that in testing out the new batteries in the remote, you've assumed a wide variety of basic facts about the world, all based on previous experience, and any of which could, in principle, be wrong. This isn't merely true of suppositions about batteries in remote controls; verification of any statement behaves this way. Looking out the window and saying, "It's raining outside," assumes that your view through the window's glass gives you an accurate picture of the outside world, and that your eyes are functioning properly, and that the dimmed light and falling droplets are in fact caused by a rain cloud and not an alien spaceship blotting out the Sun and dropping some exotic substance onto your front lawn. So you can never verify a single statement: you're always stuck verifying the entirety of your knowledge about the world, or at least a very large fraction of it. As Quine put it, "Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body."

With the verification theory of meaning left gasping for air, Quine dismissed the idea that it's meaningless to talk about unobservable things. Unverifiable statements must have meaning, because no individual statement is verifiable. Thus, the "metaphysics" so dreaded by the positivists came roaring back: rather than speaking simply of sensations, Quine contended that it was perfectly intelligible to speak of physical objects with existence independent of the speaker.

Quine's paper emboldened other thinkers who harbored doubts about logical positivism. One of them was a younger colleague of Quine's at Harvard: Thomas Kuhn. Kuhn had spoken with Quine at length while he